In the initial days of the pandemic, it fell upon us to create quarantine camps to house all our citizens being repatriated from abroad. This we did, with the first camp coming up at Manesar, and subsequently in Jodhpur and Jaisalmer where it was hoped the summer heat would kill the virus. These locations had not only to be made functional with beds, mattresses, toiletries and so on, which was comparatively easy but also manned, which was more difficult. The residents were apprehensive of their status and future and were often given to becoming unruly. Our staff manning these facilities, basically soldiers with no experience of the kind, rose to the occasion. They handled the residents with compassion and maturity and had to be very patient with them. Once the initial shock had worn off and boredom set in, we even had to keep them entertained. Some even became aggressive and disorderly, and they had to be handled with a firm hand. All these responsibilities were undertaken in the spirit of helping our citizens, for, after all, we are their Army. If we don't help them, who else will?

Our medical staff also had the onerous task of setting up and manning Covid facilities. While the infrastructure could easily be built, making it ready to accept patients and treating them is another matter altogether. The DRDO facility that was created near the IGI airport is one example. While the prefab shelters and basic facilities came up quickly enough, there was an acute shortage of doctors and nursing staff to man this facility, committed as the Army is, with manning our own service hospitals. Somehow or the other we pulled out doctors and nurses from wherever possible, training institutions and other staff assignments, and pushed them into the field. Reservists were called up and the service of those due to proceed on discharge or retirement was halted and given extension of service. Rules and regulations only vaguely heard

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